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SECURITY



Hackers exploiting SharePoint zero-day seen targeting government agencies

The hackers behind the [initial wave of attacks exploiting a zero-day in Microsoft SharePoint servers](#) have so far primarily targeted government organizations, according to researchers and news reports.

Over the weekend, U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA [published an alert](#), warning that hackers were exploiting a previously unknown bug — known as a “[zero-day](#)” — in Microsoft’s enterprise data management product SharePoint. While it’s still too early to draw definitive conclusions, it appears that the hackers who first started abusing this flaw were targeting government organizations, according to Silas Cutler, the principal researcher at Censys, a cybersecurity firm that monitors hacking activities on the internet.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

“It looks like initial exploitation was against a narrow set of targets,” Cutler told TechCrunch. “Likely government related.”

“This is a fairly rapidly evolving case. Initial exploitation of this vulnerability was likely fairly limited in terms of targeting, but as more attackers learn to replicate exploitation, we will likely see breaches as a result of this incident,” said Cutler.

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Do you have more information about these SharePoint attacks? We’d love to

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Now that the vulnerability is out there, and is still not fully patched by Microsoft, it's possible other hackers that are not necessarily working for a government will join in and start abusing it, Cutler said.

Cutler added that he and his colleagues are seeing between 9,000 and 10,000 vulnerable SharePoint instances accessible from the internet, but that could change. Eye Security, which first [published the existence of the bug](#), reported seeing a similar number, saying its researchers scanned more than 8,000 SharePoint servers worldwide and found evidence of dozens of compromised servers.

Given the limited number of targets and the types of targets at the beginning of the campaign, Cutler explained, it is likely that the hackers were part of a government group, commonly known as an [advanced persistent threat](#).



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[The Washington Post reported](#) on Sunday that the attacks targeted U.S. federal and state agencies, as well as universities and energy companies, among other commercial targets.

Microsoft [said in a blog post](#) that the vulnerability only affects versions of SharePoint that are installed on local networks, and not the cloud versions, which means that each organization that deploys a SharePoint server needs to apply the patch or disconnect it from the internet.

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since the bug was discovered last week.

Eye Security, a Dutch cybersecurity firm that [first identified the vulnerability](#) in SharePoint, a popular server software that companies use to store and share internal documents, said it had identified hundreds of affected SharePoint servers by scanning the internet. The number has risen from the dozens of known compromised servers as of [earlier this week](#).

Bloomberg [reports](#) that one of the affected organizations includes the National Nuclear Security Administration (NNSA), the federal agency responsible for maintaining and developing the U.S. stockpile of nuclear weapons. Ben Dietderich, a spokesperson for the Department of Energy, which

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houses the NNSA, confirmed the department was “minimally impacted,” and that a “very small number of systems were impacted.”

Several [other government departments and agencies](#) were also compromised in an early wave of attacks exploiting the SharePoint bug, researchers confirmed. Data suggests hackers were exploiting the vulnerability as early as July 7.

The bug, officially known as [CVE-2025-53770](#), affects self-hosted versions of SharePoint that companies set up and manage on their own servers. Once exploited, the bug allows an attacker to remotely run malicious code on the affected server, permitting access to the files stored inside, as well as other systems on the company’s wider network.

The vulnerability is known as a [zero-day](#) because Microsoft had no time to release patches before it was exploited. Microsoft has since released patches for all affected SharePoint versions.

Google and Microsoft say they have evidence that [several China-backed hacking groups are exploiting the bug](#), but warned companies to expect an uptick in compromises as more hacker groups seek to take advantage of the vulnerability. The Chinese government denied the allegations.

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Updated with comment from the Department of Energy.

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New zero-day bug in Microsoft SharePoint under widespread attack

Zack Whittaker — 5:50 AM PDT · July 21, 2025



Microsoft

The U.S. federal government and cybersecurity researchers say a newly discovered security bug found in Microsoft's SharePoint is under attack.

U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA **sounded the alarm this weekend** that hackers were actively exploiting the bug. Microsoft has not yet provided patches for all affected SharePoint versions, leaving customers across the world largely unable to defend against the ongoing intrusions.

IMAGE CREDITS:
NICOLAS ECONOMOU / NURPHOT / GETTY IMAGES

Microsoft said the bug, known officially as **CVE-2025-53770**, affects versions of SharePoint that companies set up and manage on their own servers. SharePoint lets companies store, share, and manage their internal files.

Microsoft said it is working on security fixes to prevent hackers from exploiting the vulnerability. The flaw, described as a **"zero-day"** because the vendor was given no time to patch the bug before it was made aware of it, affects versions of the software as old as SharePoint Server 2016.

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It's not yet known how many servers have been compromised so far, but it is likely thousands of small to medium-sized businesses that rely on the software are affected. According to [The Washington Post](#), several U.S. federal agencies, universities, and energy companies have already been breached in the attacks.

Eye Security, which [first revealed the bug](#) on Saturday, said it found “dozens” of actively exploited Microsoft SharePoint servers online at the time of its publication. The bug, when exploited, allows hackers to steal private digital keys from SharePoint servers without needing any credentials to log in. Once in, the hackers can remotely plant malware and gain access to the files and data stored within. Eye Security warned that SharePoint connects with other apps, like Outlook, Teams, and OneDrive, which may enable further network compromise and data theft.

Eye Security said because the bug involves the theft of digital keys that can be used to impersonate legitimate requests on the server, affected customers must both patch the bug and take additional steps to rotate their digital keys to prevent the hackers from recompromising the server.

CISA and others have urged customers to “take immediate recommended action.” In the absence of patches or mitigations, customers should consider disconnecting potentially affected systems from the internet.

“If you have SharePoint [on-premise] exposed to the internet, you should assume that you have been compromised at this point,” said Michael Sikorski, the head of Palo Alto Networks’ threat intelligence division Unit 42, in an email to TechCrunch.

It's also not yet known who is carrying out the attacks on SharePoint servers, but it is the latest in a string of cyberattacks targeting Microsoft customers in recent years.

In 2021, a China-backed hacking group dubbed Hafnium was caught exploiting a vulnerability found in self-hosted Microsoft Exchange email servers, allowing [the mass-hacking and exfiltration of email and contacts data from businesses](#) around the world. The hackers compromised more than 60,000 servers, according to a [recent Justice Department indictment](#) accusing two Chinese nationals of masterminding the operation.

Two years later, Microsoft confirmed a cyberattack on its cloud systems, which it manages directly, allowing Chinese hackers to [steal a sensitive email signing key](#) that permitted access to both consumer and enterprise email accounts hosted by the company.

Microsoft has also reported [repeated intrusions](#) from hackers associated with the Russian government.

Do you know more about the SharePoint cyberattacks? Are you an affected customer? Securely contact this reporter via encrypted message at [zackwhittaker.1337](#) on Signal.

An earlier version of this story stated the incorrect CVE number; the story has been amended to note the correct vulnerability, CVE-2025-53770.

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